

Przeworski et al 2000 RG Notes

Przeworski, Adam, Michael E. Alvarez, Jose Antonio Cheibub, and Fernando Limongi. *Democracy and Development: Political Institutions and Well-Being in the World, 1950–1990*.

New York: Cambridge University Press, 2000.

1 Main Idea

2 General Notes

- “The world around us is not generated randomly. The world we observe is a result of actions of people pursuing their ends. It nurtures successes and eliminates failures. These processes are systematic, and so are their effects. The search for randomness is futile; we must proceed differently. The question is how.”
“To cope with the non-random nature of our observations, we revert to counterfactuals. To evaluate institutions, to assess their impact, we must ask what the outcomes would have been if other institutions had been observed under the same conditions. And if their selection is not random, these institutions are not observable under the same conditions. Hence, a recourse to counterfactuals is unavoidable.”
- Contestation requires three virtues (largely defined by Przeworski’s *a system in which parties lose elections*):
 1. Ex-ante uncertainty: some positive probability that some member of the ruling government will lose an election
 2. Ex-post irreversibility: whoever wins the election will assuredly assume office
 3. Repeatability: whoever gains office will not rewrite the electoral institutions such that they guarantee a future win
- Though there are certainly examples (especially in 20th century) of autocracies experiencing significant economic growth, generally not controversial that democracy seems to be correlated with development – the question is the direction of causality; it is often claimed (here argued incorrectly so) that democracy itself causes this economic growth.
- Distinction between two core causal mechanisms: emergence and survival. Data shows

that while democracies are not necessarily more likely to emerge as economic development increases, when economic hardship is introduced, a democratic system is much more likely to fail than an authoritarian system. Subsequently, there emerges a survivorship bias, as those democracies which experience poor economic results are effectively no longer categorized as democracies. Conversely, dictatorship survival is less tied to economic development – “dictatorships die under the entire range of economic conditions.” pg. 111

- “The most important lesson we have learned is that wealthy countries tend to be democratic not because democracies emerge as a consequence of economic development under dictatorships but because, however they emerge, democracies are much more likely to survive in affluent societies. We find it difficult to explain why dictatorships die and democracies emerge. Although we are willing to believe that economic development may open the possibility for transition to democracy, even when the conditions for democracy are ripe, the outcomes of political conflicts are indeterminate. Hence, we failed to detect any thresholds of development that would make the emergence of democracy predictable. In sum, modernization theory appears to have little, if any, explanatory power.” pg. 137

3 Important Specific Factual Claims

- “A myopic public has to be protected from itself; economic reforms must be carried out before the people have time to react. This is still a popular belief.” pg. 4
- Good section on methodology in the introduction – discusses how measuring welfare via income is inherently incomplete, as well as the difficulty of democracies turning into dictatorships when the economy is bad (makes it very hard to continuously code data and will cause an apparent shock to the democratic results)

4 Connections

- Strong tie between the above discussion of counterfactuals and Mill’s system of inductive logic & reasoning: application of Mill’s approach to comparative institutions (may need to verify that they are exactly aligned though)
- Heavy tie to Dahl’s polyarchy: Przeworski et al focus on contestation as the primary distinction between democracies and non-democracies, whereby democracies feature legitimately contested political power and influence (most notably the executive and the legislature)
- Very aligned with Huntington 1968 in that a lack of political development can be destabilizing in the face of economic growth: if political institutions are not sufficiently developed to endure greater participation and interest (namely, democracies should be very well-equipped to do so), then we should expect to see instability; here, instability is tied to survival of the regime as a whole

5 My Critiques

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